

Benefits scandal

State Secretary De Vries corrects her own figures on deceased children receiving

**Trouw**

The House of Representatives was incorrectly informed about the number of deaths among young adult victims of childcare benefits. State Secretary Aukje de Vries apologizes profusely.



State Secretary Aukje de Vries (allowances) during a debate on the benefits scandal. ANP

Esther Lammers June 12, 2023, 23:30



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She made an extremely painful mistake, VVD State Secretary Aukje de Vries (benefits) acknowledges in a letter to the House of Representatives on Tuesday. Not 256 young adult children of



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parents receiving benefits died after all, as she reported on Monday, but 62.

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Her letter now states that a total of 482 children receiving benefits have died over the past 17 years. The new figure of 62 deceased young adults is a factor of four lower than what the minister mentioned on Monday evening, but is in line with what she reported earlier.

According to the minister, it is 'terrible and regrettable' that this has caused 'confusion' and 'emotions' within the House. She calls the misunderstanding 'painful' and 'bitter', particularly for the parents affected by this. After all, the cabinet wanted to show precisely that these children were 'seen and acknowledged'.

De Vries does not mention how the misunderstanding arose. She simply mixed up two figures. The mentioned number of 256 young adults refers to the deceased children who would have been 18 or older on July 1, 2023 (the reference date). Depending on the age on the reference date, parents receive a compensation amount. The exact age at which the children died is listed in another table. The vast majority of the deceased children were younger than five.

Emotional reactions

The House of Representatives reacted with shock and emotion on Monday to the State Secretary's figures. VVD MP Mariëlle Paul was even speechless for a moment. De Vries was also surprised that the number of young adult deaths was so high. She understood very

Twell the 'sensitive nature' of this subject and the 'emotional reactions', she said.

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The MPs are relieved about the correction letter, but they do call it 'very painful'. Renske Leijten of the SP is pleased that clarification is coming 'so quickly' and that the error has been rectified. "Precisely on such a sensitive subject, you want the utmost care to be taken," she says. Denk MP Farid Azarkan agrees: "This story must not take on a life of its own." He does believe, however, that State Secretary De Vries handled the information 'too carelessly' and was clearly 'not well-versed in the subject matter'. "You cannot make such a mistake on such a fragile dossier," says Azarkan.

MP Pieter Omtzigt points out that "nearly 500 children have still died." He hopes that an independent investigation into the deaths will be launched soon. De Vries also fails to answer the House's core question: "We want to know whether these deaths deviate from what can be statistically expected in the group? Not even the beginning of an answer has been given to that question."

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